

Al Mallette

Big Shows



This is quite a night for the sports buff. If you like your action live, get over to the Academy gym (get there like 4 this afternoon) and sit in on what might be the best basketball show in some time—Mansfield vs. Academy.

Tom McMillen, Mansfield's all-everything, is the principal attraction. But Academy's Danny Gilliam, if he's healthy, isn't bad to watch, either. Danny's been battling the virus bug recently, but hopefully he'll be fit tonight.

If make-believe boxing is your dish and you like to travel a few miles, hop up to Syracuse and sit in on the computerized movie matching Rocky Marciano and Cassius Clay—if it isn't boycotted as the report indicates is possible.

I've seen a couple of short previews of the films, showing Clay giving Rocky the worst of it. But if this doesn't end in a Marciano kayo, somebody better look into the computer.

If you like the comforts of home (and who doesn't these icicle nights) you have a double-dip—NBA All-Star basketball and NHL All-Star hockey (who goofed on that scheduling?). If you can switch dials fast enough, you might get to see all of your favorites in both sports doing their thing.

Me, I'll be battling the crowd, the noise and the hoopla at the Academy gym. This could be the last chance we'll get to see McMillen play basketball in Elmira.

ANDY COHEN, the Elmira Baseball Hall of Famer who now is baseball coach at Texas, commented, "I got here two weeks early. I'd much rather be here Feb. 2 to honor that great little hustler, Earl Weaver.

"Let me tell you, your folks are paying tribute to one of the grandest little guys I know. And what an array of talent you've got on the dais. You folks go big league here. But then I've always considered Elmira big league, anyway.

"Another thing, I think the Pioneers have themselves a great little manager coming up this year, too. Harry Malmberg is a real student of the game. He was a great competitor and he's a good manager. Harry, you know, was second baseman at Minneapolis when I had Weaver at Denver."

ANDY PAUSED a moment then said, "Did I ever tell you the story on how I turned down probably the greatest second baseman of modern times? It was in the Fifties when I managed at Denver and had Weaver with me.

"Branch Rickey called me one day and told me I was being moved from Denver to New Orleans as manager and that he had a young second baseman he wanted me to take and teach. 'You were a second baseman,' he told me, 'and I want you to take this boy under your wing.'

"I told Rickey that I already had a second baseman and that I wanted Weaver to accompany me to New Orleans. Mr. Rickey argued. So did I. It very probably was the first and only time Mr. Rickey ever relented. But I insisted on Weaver because he could do so many more things than play second base. And I told Mr. Rickey that.

"Well, Mr. Rickey was very perturbed. But he agreed to let me have Weaver at New Orleans. He shipped the other boy to Williamsport in the Eastern League. He did turn out to be a good one (the other "ballplayer was Bill Mazeroski).

"But look at Earl. He did pretty good for himself, too. And maybe my taking him to New Orleans with me had a part in it."